grandmother and father assassinated while still in his teens, had been forced to change his surname at Cambridge to ensure security, and had consciously shunned the limelight. And yes, he was still a bachelor.

His mother and sister had adopted different trajectories. Sonia Gandhi had entered politics in 1998 after a bloodless but rather unseemly coup in which veteran Congressman Sitaram Kesri had been removed overnight as party president. Rahul's sister Priyanka Gandhi had married young, was a mother of two and had also acquired a slight political profile while handling Sonia's campaign in 1999. I had spent a day filming with her at the time and must confess was thoroughly charmed. Forthcoming and attractive, with a striking resemblance to her grandmother Indira, Priyanka had then come across to me as a potential leader for the future. I still remember a local UP Congress leader, Akhilesh Singh, telling me, '*Dekhna, ek din Priyankaji bahut badi neta banegi!'* (Priyanka will one day become a big leader.)

All that changed in 2004 when it was formally announced that Rahul Gandhi would be the Congress candidate for Amethi, the seat from where his father Rajiv and uncle Sanjay had contested. That general election was expected to offer little hope to the Congress's declining fortunes. The BJP, under Atal Bihari Vajpayee, was the overwhelming favourite for a hat-trick of victories. India Shining was the buzzword and most opinion polls were predicting a comprehensive win for Vajpayee, the BJP's original vikas purush.

After we broadcast the results of one such pre-poll survey, I was called for an informal chat with Sonia Gandhi to her residence at 10, Janpath. It was only the second time I had visited the home of the Congress leadership; the previous occasion was an interview with Sonia Gandhi after a court order had exonerated Rajiv Gandhi in the Bofors case. With life-size pictures of Rajiv Gandhi on the wall and photographs of Nehru and Indira, the main room in 10, Janpath is an in-your-face reminder of the family tree that has dominated the country's post-independence politics. It can also be a little intimidating since there is an almost eerie silence when you enter. 'Are you sure we are doing so badly as your polls suggest?' was Mrs Gandhi's